MENDER-IN-CHIEF



Gujarat deputy CM **Harsh Sanghavi** is now the government's go-to troubleshooter for politically sensitive negotiations. The recent resolution of the two-week-long farmers' agitation in Morbi over compensation for land acquired for an Adani-linked project was another indication of this. Local BJP MLA Kanti Amrutiya could not persuade the government to meet the protesters halfway, and the embarrassment got worse after his brothers joined the agitation as well. Delhi then roped in Sanghavi, and the state finally reached a temporary compromise with the protesters.

LIVE CIRCUS



Nishad Party chief and Uttar Pradesh minister **Sanjay Nishad** found himself in the news for all the wrong reasons at a workers' conference in Jalaun recently. A routine felicitation soon turned into a war of words between him and the party's state secretary, Bharat Lal, all of it with the microphones on. The party chief was heard telling Lal "*dimaag sahi kar lo* (fix your mind)", or he would fix it. Lal, in turn, complained that years of hard work had got him zilch in terms of opportunities. With the mikes relaying every nuance of the public spectacle, the meme makers had a field day.

AN ENEMY WITHIN



The Goa assembly poll, expected by this year-end, has begun to acquire a familiar Congress twist. After nearly 15 years out of power, the party had just started to sound confident about reclaiming the state, aided by reports of anti-incumbency against the ruling BJP. But then comes news of a new outfit, the Goa Congress, allegedly floated by disgruntled ex-partymen. The development has resuscitated that old question again: will the Congress be defeated by its opponents, or by its own internal contradictions?

Kaushik Deka **with** ***Amitabh Srivastava, Jumana Shah, Avaneesh Mishra*** **and** ***Dhaval S. Kulkarni***

ECO WATCH

NEW SPECIES
INDIA BEATS OWN RECORD

By **Jumana Shah**

India added a record 709 species to its faunal database and 353 taxa to its floral database in 2025, marking the country's highest annual biodiversity additions since systematic documentation began. The findings, released in the Animal Discoveries 2025 and Plant Discoveries 2025 reports by the Zoological Survey of India and Botanical Survey of India, respectively, reinforced India's status as one of the world's 17 megadiverse nations.

Of the 709 faunal additions, 483 species are new to science, while 226 species have been recorded in India for the first time. The plant discoveries comprise 221 taxa new to science and 132 new distribution records for the country. Together, they take India's documented faunal diversity to 105,953 species and subspecies.

The record-breaking tally reflects not only India's immense biological wealth but also intensified taxonomic surveys, improved exploration of remote landscapes and advances in molecular techniques that are helping scientists distinguish previously overlooked species. Among those is a new variant of the non-venomous wolf's snake, discovered on the Great Nicobar Island. The glossy black coloured *Lycodon irwini*, which can grow up to 1.2 metres in length, was named after the late Australian conservationist and TV show host, Steve Irwin.



Black beauty Lycodon irwini (Irwin's wolf snake)

The geographical pattern of discoveries highlights two of India's richest biodiversity hotspots. Kerala's Western Ghats section recorded the highest number of new animal discoveries with 98 species. On the botanical front, Arunachal Pradesh emerged as the leader with 49 plant discoveries.